Though overshadowed by attacks on the Indian embassy and consulates after 2008, these kidnappings were formative in India's understanding of the neo-Taliban. Deeply concerned about the robustness of India's crisis response mechanisms in Afghanistan, where nearly 2,000 Indians were residing in those years, gaining knowledge about the Taliban became imperative for Indian policymakers.[18] Narayanan remembers Manmohan Singh asking him often about what India was doing to ensure the safety of its citizens and projects in Afghanistan, and whether adequate contingency plans were in place in case of a crisis.[19] Kutty and Suryanarayana's killing had rankled Indian policymakers, who began highlighting changes in the Taliban's modus operandi of swiftly killing the captives. As senior Congress MP Santosh Bagrodia pointed out that, 'on earlier occasions, they [Taliban] held protracted negotiations before releasing the captives', so what could be the inherent motive for change in the *modus operandi* of the Taliban in this case?[20] Various Left parties sought similar clarifications. The CPM, otherwise staunchly anti-Taliban, pressed the government to directly reach out to the abductors. For domestic political reasons, and to gain sympathy among families of Keralite workers abroad, the communists questioned the necessity and logic behind India's prompt statement that the highway construction would continue unabated.[21] Without actually changing its policy, India could have let the 48-hour deadline pass before reaffirming its commitment towards Afghanistan. The salience of this question increased in the wake of an ostensible shift in the Taliban's tactics.

There was no shift in the Taliban's *modus operandi* per se. Different Taliban factions with divergent interests and aims had undertaken the kidnappings. One faction was rooted in Afghanistan and had linkages with local political leaders and tribal elders, while the other operated out of Pakistan and was allegedly sustained by Pakistan's security establishment. Kidnapping-for-ransom and extortion were ways by which the former survived financially, whereas it was simply a tool of coercion used by the latter with little accruing financial benefits. In such a scenario, it was easy to deal with those Taliban elements that operated from within Afghanistan and could be engaged with via tribal elders and other governmental and religious figures. Within six months of the kidnapping of Indian workers, for instance, Mullah Sabir Momin denounced Mullah Omar and